

IN PROFILE

Domenico Barbaja

Rossini's dealings with Barbaja (1778–1841), the most dynamic impresario of the age, played a major part in his career. Described by contemporaries as disreputable, Barbaja made his first fortune with a gambling empire, which exploited the passion for the new game of roulette. He subsequently acquired theaters in Naples, Milan, and Vienna. Barbaja had a keen eye for talent, but he worked his composers ruthlessly. Rossini was contracted to deliver two operas a year, as well as assisting with the staging of other productions. "If he could, he would have had me working in the kitchen as well," Rossini noted ruefully.



DOMENICO BARBAJA IN NAPLES IN THE 1820s

Breakthrough and success

Rossini's early operas were rather repetitive, but with *Tancredi* he came of age. Set in 11th-century Syracuse, this opera seria placed a tender love story against the backdrop of a war between Sicily and its Saracen enemies. *Tancredi* was a slow starter at the box office, but Rossini's melodies soon caught on. One aria in particular, "Di tanti palpiti" ("After such palpitations"), became a favorite with the